

Douglas DC-3/C-47



“It was the first airplane that could make money just by hauling passengers.”

C.R. SMITH

LONG-TIME PRESIDENT OF AMERICAN AIRLINES



EXTENDED SERVICE

The DC-3 revolutionized commercial aviation: by 1939, three out of every four American air passengers was traveling in a DC-3. Some airlines, like Mohawk Airlines (shown here), continued to use DC-3s into the 1960s.

THE DOUGLAS C-47 (known as the Dakota in Britain) was the military transport version of the DC-3, the most successful passenger aircraft of the 1930s. The DC-3 was apparently the result of a two-hour phone conversation between the president of American Airlines and Donald Douglas, founder of the Douglas Aircraft Company. Douglas was persuaded to produce a larger version of the DC-2, adapted for use as a 14-berth sleeper. This plane, the Douglas Sleeper Transport (DST) was soon eclipsed by the

success of the 21-seat DC-3 version of the same aircraft, which first flew in 1935.

The robust virtues of the DC-3 were legion. It was reliable and easy to service – an engine could be changed in under two hours. It could operate equally well off dirt, grass, or concrete airfields. And it was considered virtually indestructible. The story is told of a DC-3 that had a wing shot off on the ground in China during the war with Japan. After being fitted with a spare wing from a DC-2 – considerably shorter than its own – it flew successfully to Hong Kong. The military transport version entered service in 1942 and soon became the universal workhorse of the Allies in WWII.

Variable-pitch propeller

Pratt & Whitney radial engine

Specifications (C-47)

ENGINE 2 x 1,200hp P&W R-1830 Twin Wasp air-cooled radial

WINGSPAN 95ft (29m)

LENGTH 64ft 6in (19.7m)

WEIGHT 16,976lb (7,700kg)

CRUISING SPEED 185mph (298kph)

CREW 3

PASSENGERS 27 troops

ENDURING APPEAL

By the war's end, neither the C-47 (shown here) nor the DC-3 were state-of-the-art, but the airplanes just kept flying. In 1958, on the threshold of the jet age in commercial aviation, there were still more DC-3s in operation in the United States than any other commercial airplane.

US Civil Registration Number shows this to be a C-47

Fabric-covered metal rudder

All-metal wing

Tailwheel (non-retractable)

Fabric-covered metal aileron

